THE HACK YOU COMMENTED FOR

B.R.T.: How to Say No at Work Without Explaining Yourself

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Write your one sentence before they ask

B.R.T. is the broken record technique. It comes from *When I Say No, I Feel Guilty*, a book by psychologist Manuel J. Smith. It only works if you know what you're going to say before anyone asks.

Keep it short and polite, and don't give a reason. You should be able to say it three times without sounding rude.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **A coworker hands you their work:** "I can't take that on right now."
>
> **A "quick favor" on Slack:** "I don't have room for that this week."
>
> **Taking notes in the meeting again:** "I'm going to pass on notes this time."
>
> **Another team's ask:** "That's not something I can pick up."

Pick the one that matches the ask you get most and save it in your phone notes.

2 Say it, then stop talking

Most people say no and then keep talking. They add "sorry" or "it's just that," and now they're halfway to a yes.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Them:** "Can you put the deck together for Thursday? You're so good at these."
>
> **You:** "I can't take that on right now."
>
> Then stop. Let them talk next.

Count to three in your head after you say it. It'll feel awkward. That's fine.

3 When they push, say it again word for word

This is the broken record part. You can show them you heard them, but don't argue. Then say the exact same sentence.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Them:** "It'll only take an hour."
>
> **You:** "I get that. I can't take that on right now."
>
> **Them:** "Nobody else knows how to do it."
>
> **You:** "That makes sense. I can't take that on right now."

If you change your words, they'll just argue with the new ones.

4 Know the three things that make you cave

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Giving a reason.** You say "I'm swamped with the launch." They say "The launch is done Friday, so just do it Monday." Now you've got nothing left to say.
>
> **The compliment.** "You're the only one who does this right." Say thanks, then say your sentence.
>
> **The half yes.** "Let me see what I can do." To them, that's a yes. Expect a follow-up tomorrow.

If you hear yourself say "because," stop mid-sentence and say your line instead.

5 Use a different sentence with your manager

With your manager, don't just say no. Ask them what to drop, and keep asking the same question.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Manager:** "Can you also own the vendor review?"
>
> **You:** "I can. What should I move to make room?"
>
> **Manager:** "Just fit it in."
>
> **You:** "Happy to. What should I move to make room?"

Now they have to pick. That's their job anyway.

- [ ] My one sentence is in my phone notes
- [ ] It has no "because" in it
- [ ] I've said it out loud three times so it doesn't come out shaky
- [ ] My manager line is ready: "What should I move to make room?"
- [ ] If I cave once, I use it on the very next ask anyway

And always remember, I'm rooting for you.